

1.2 Poetry: voice, image and form

Paper 1 Drama and Poetry · 2026 examination · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Distinguish poet from speaker. Sound, imagery, line breaks, stanza patterns and shifts in tone make meaning together; naming a metaphor without explaining its effect earns little. Analyse how an image develops across the poem and how form changes the reader's pace or expectation.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

A line ending “still” may momentarily suggest calm before the next line reveals “still falling”; the break delays interpretation and dramatizes uncertainty.

Original practice stimulus

The clock kept rain inside its face;
At noon the windows learned to blur.
We counted hours along the glass
Until the numbers lost their order.
A hand moved on. The hallway stayed.
Outside, the buses wore the weather.
I thought a voice had called my name;
The door gave back the sound of water.
By evening, every minute shone
Like something briefly held, then gone.

Extended response

Compose your response in the space provided and support your interpretation with evidence.

1 Original lines: "The clock kept rain inside its face. / At noon the windows learned to blur." Explore two possible effects of the imagery and line break. [25]

Check: relevant evidence · coherent argument · accurate and deliberate language

Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25 marks]

A strong answer connects clock/rain metaphor to time and weather, notes personification “windows learned,” considers unstable perceptions, and discusses pacing created by the break. Ground interpretations in the exact original wording.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or calculation error; then retry without looking at the solution.

Syllabus: Literature in English 9695, 2024–2026.

<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/636097-2024-2026-syllabus.pdf>

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